Swapsies

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Characters:
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by Paganaidd

Summary

Entrapta experiments with a new portal. Catra volunteers to help. Hijinks ensue

Notes

This story can stand alone, but it also fits into my "Tell Me Everything" timeline. It takes place after Chapter 5 of Fighting Sleep.
If you read this as a one-shot, here is the context:

Several months after the war, the Etherian Horde has been renamed the Horde Republic and is run by a council, the head of which is Scorpia. Catra and Adora were married in a traditional Horde Ceremony. Catra was ill for a few weeks and just returned to work. Adora is having trouble figuring out where She Ra fits in anymore.

The dark vaulted ceiling looked familiar as Catra lay on the floor, trying to puzzle out where the fuck she was. Experimentally, she raised her right arm to brush her bangs out of her face (she really ought to decide what to do about her hair).

Okay, good. Nothing hurt when she moved. Nothing prevented her from moving.

Holding herself still, she felt the surface underneath her with both hands: warm concrete. She breathed deeply through her nose and mouth, tasting the air.

Memory filled in.

"Entrapta, I am going to fucking kill you!" she swore.

"Hey, Adora?" said the familiar voice through the communicator in Adora's ear. Weirdly, it was not Catra, although it was her access code.

"Go ahead, Scorpia," Adora said, glad she had remembered to take her earbud out before she transformed so it had not just disappeared with the rest of her clothes. She did not want to explain what she was doing to Catra.

"Ah. Yeah. Sorry to bother you. We have a Situation here." Scorpia paused nervously. "It… um… It's hard to explain."

Adora's heart stuttered to a halt. Catra had gone to the Republic Capital for the first time since the war today (no one wanted to call it the Fright Zone anymore, but no one had come up with a better name) to help Entrapta with some secret project.

"Is Catra okay?" Adora was already walking rapidly to the entrance. Her skiff was parked just outside the Temple. She would call Glimmer and get a teleport if it was an emergency, but she did not want to have to explain what she was doing here to Glimmer either.

"Well, yes and no…," Scorpia said slowly.

Entrapta interrupted. "Hi, Adora! Catra is perfectly okay physically! Well, as far as I can tell, anyway. But she's hiding under my workbench, and she won't come out."

Gingerly, the magicat sat up to take stock of her surroundings.

The dark basement was full of crates and smelled of oil, diesel fumes, and smoke. Definitely not where she was supposed to be. This was supposed to be a test foray into the kind of pocket dimension that had been created by Hordak and Entrapta's machinery years ago. But if that was the case, it should be empty. This looked nothing like the white void Melog had described. Instead, it looked, felt, and smelled like the old Fright Zone. In fact, it looked very much like the warehouse where Entrapta had her lab set up.

Catra took a deep breath, reminding herself that they had *planned* for this kind of contingency. She could not feel Melog, which meant they were not nearby, but her friend had assured her they could find her anywhere in the universe, including alternate dimensions. So Catra volunteered to go, and Melog stayed with Scorpia and Entrapta. In the likely event it went awry, Melog would find her and help direct the portal to get her home. She only needed to keep herself safe and wait for extraction.

This area seemed pretty safe. Seldom used going by the dust in the corners. She should have brought a book to read.

Adora's stomach dropped. Shit. "Let me call Glimmer! I'll be right there!"

"Good idea, if she's free. But you should probably know… "

"Tell me when I get there," Adora ended the call. She pressed the outgoing call button on the device in her ear. "Call Glimmer. Emergency access tag," she told the communicator. That would get through even if Glimmer set Do Not Disturb on her trackpad.

For a few minutes, Catra lay curled up on the tallest crate she could find, tail wrapped around her, in waiting-for-action-but-reserving-energy mode (Arrow Boy called it napping, but whatever). She would need to get up and look for water eventually (she could go for days without food, but water was more urgent). For now, she allowed herself to be lulled by the warmth and the familiar Fright Zone scents.

A persistent sound roused her to full alertness. Someone was crying. Catra sat up, turning her ears and head to locate it. She hopped off the crate and paced to the end of the warehouse. There was a door to a supply room. It was locked from the outside, and the crying was behind it.

Conflict boiled up in Catra's chest as she put her hand on the door handle. The smart thing would be to leave it alone; it wasn't her problem. She did not know where she was or what she would find behind that door. It looked like a supply closet, but it could be a pit filled with sharp-toothed predators, and crying children could

be their lure. The fact that it locked from the outside was a point in favor of that.

The sobbing behind the door turned to breathless hiccups and then back to sobs with no sign of abating. The person making all the noise sounded very young, and there was only one voice.

“This is a terrible idea,” Catra muttered to herself, slowly opening the door.

“What. Happened,” She Ra demanded, almost before she and Glimmer fully materialized. Scorpia and Entrapta, both on their knees in front of the workbench, twisted around to look at them, although Perfuma was on her stomach, elbow crawling almost under the workbench. The giantess shimmered away, leaving only Adora to shakily kneel between Perfuma’s prone form and Scorpia, who scooted over to make room. Entrapta got up and started pacing.

An ugly, high-pitched growl came from under the bench. Adora put her face near the floor so she could see what was making the noise. One blue and one yellow eye shone steadily in the darkness.

“Catra?” Adora started to ask. “What’s going…”

“Wait,” Scorpia gently put her pincer on Adora’s shoulder, exerting a little pressure to get her to sit up again. “That isn't Catra. At least not our Catra,” Scorpia said seriously.

Adora gave in to the pressure and came up to her knees. “What is that supposed to mean?” she demanded.

“Okay, well, here is where it gets complicated,” Scorpia replied, looking at Entrapta pacing behind them, muttering furiously as her

hair took dictation. “Entrapta?” Scorpia called, raising her voice a little. “Tell them what you told me!”

“Huh?” The purple-haired woman jerked, startled out of whatever calculations she was making, and stared at them as though surprised by their presence. She blinked, and her face cleared. “Oh, right!” She returned to stand beside Adora and bent to look under the workbench. The growling got louder. “I made a time portal!” crowed Entrapta, unable to keep the excitement out of her voice. “I sent Catra back in time!”

Scorpia raised her eyebrows and cocked her head at Entrapta.

The woman’s face went blank, and then she bit her lip.“And it was a total mistake, and I need to figure out how to fix it!” Entrapta finished quickly.

The door swung open with a metallic creak. An alarmed squeak interrupted the crying. A light-haired little girl jumped up and stepped backward, tripping over a piece of debris on the floor and scrambling back until her head hit the wall. The girl gasped, and then she curled up into a defensive ball like she thought she was going to get hit or something. “I’msorryI’msorry,” she whimpered.

“Hey, it’s okay,” Catra said much more calmly than she felt. The girl was maybe four or five by her size. A stack of rations sat in the corner with several water bottles. A bucket toilet sat in the other corner. The smell of the place told Catra how long the girl had been there, making the magicat swallow hard. She crouched, trying to get down to the little girl’s level, but she did not go into the room-- no way in hell was she going to take a chance of that door slamming shut. “I won’t hurt you.”

“P-promise?” the girl was nearly hyperventilating, so terrified she could not get out of her huddle.

Catra shifted her weight, sitting with her legs crisscrossed and her back against the open door. She put her elbows on her knees and rested her chin on her hands, settling in while she waited for the girl to get herself under control. "I promise."

Minutes stretched on while a sick feeling rose in Catra's stomach, and all the magicat's fur stood on end; something was very wrong here.

The little girl finally raised her head, wiping her eyes and squinting into the darkness. "Hey! I can see you!" she exclaimed, surprise momentarily removing the fear from her voice and expression. "You have eyes exactly like my friend! They shine in the dark, too! And hers don't match, either!"

Catra's breath caught in her throat. She *knew* this little girl. She knew those eyes, that blonde hair, those gapped teeth. And now that the girl scooted closer, the industrial fumes could no longer cover up her scent. Realization dawned, slow and chilling.

What the *fuck* had Entrapta done? This was just supposed to be a little jaunt, not even trying to find the old queen this time. This was meant to be a quick proof-of-concept where she dipped into a pocket dimension and then came back.

But this… Now that Catra thought about it had Entrapta said something about time travel nonsense? Yes, Catra definitely remembered something about that being a possibility, but she had tuned it out along with all the talk of unstable wormholes.

"Are you… Your name's Adora?" Catra asked thickly.

All the curiosity drained from the girl's face as if asking her name made her remember where she was. She jumped up to come to attention and saluted with a shaking hand. "Yes, ma'am," she whispered.

"At ease." Catra cleared her throat. "It's fine. Sit down." obediently, the girl sat on the floor, sitting with her knees almost touching Catra's.

“What… What are you doing down here?” Catra asked. She had a hard time keeping her voice level because she feared she knew the answer.

“I’m grounded.” The child sniffed and wiped her nose with her sleeve.

Catra took a deep breath to keep her growl down to a minimum. “What for?”

“Sh-shadow Weaver is trying to teach me to be brave.”

“You made a new portal?” Glimmer asked in a dangerously soft voice then turned to Scorpia. “You said she could do this?” her cheeks were drained of color, but Adora could not tell if she was angry or afraid.

Scorpia tapped the ends of her claws together in front of her face nervously. “Yes?”’ Then she lowered her claws and asserted, “But she has a really good reason!”

“What possible reason…?” Glimmer started to ask, then she shook her head, throwing her hands up in the air. “You know what? Never mind. Forget I asked. I’ll convene an Alliance meeting, and we’ll yell at you later.” She turned her back on them and pointed at the workbench. “But if it’s not Catra, who’s under there?”

“Well, if my hypothesis is correct,” chirped Entrapta, “when Catra went through the portal, in order to prevent a paradox, the two versions of Catra swapped places. I suspect it’s some sort of natural magical law at work, preventing two versions of the same person from existing simultaneously.”

“Wait,” Perfuma began. “How would… “

Glimmer put a hand on Perfuma's arm to cut her off. "Just go with it," she whispered before Entrapta derailed the story with exposition.

Fortunately, Entrapta had not heard. "So we have Catra 1.0 trading places with Catra 2.0. Or maybe she's a larval Catra? I'll have to look up the proper term for magicat young."

Scorpia sighed and said, "So yeah, Catra went through the portal, and then she came out. Only she was… kind of pocket-sized."

"Pocket-sized?" Adora blinked, trying to follow what Scorpia was trying to say. "What do you mean… pocket-sized?"

"My data says she is average-sized for five-year-old magicats!" said Entrapta, looking at her tablet. "Oh, according to this reference, they are commonly called kittens until they reach their teens, and then they are called kits."

They were getting so sidetracked. Adora grabbed Scorpia's pincer and shook it. "Tell. Me. What. Happened."

The big woman sighed. "Entrapta turned the thing on, and Catra walked through." Scorpia waved at the pieces of equipment lying around the lab. Some of it looked scorched. Not uncommon in Entrapta's lab, but this appeared pretty fresh. "It started to overload or something."

Of course, it did.

"And then: pakow!" Scorpia mimed an explosion with her claws. "We were behind that." She pointed to an eight-foot-tall, ten-foot-wide metal wall with a window set into it at eye level. It had scorch marks on it, too. "When the smoke cleared, little Catra was standing where grown Catra had just left." The Etherian Horde's Princess sagged, dropping her pincers in her lap. "I tried to talk to her, you know, to calm her down, but she took one look at this place," Scorpia said mournfully, waving her pincer to indicate the brightly lit lab. "And took off under there.".

“Poor thing! She must be so scared!” Perfuma put in. “How will we get her out?” She put her face down near the floor to look for the girl again.

“Well, I guess we could unbolt the bench from the floor and grab her that way,” Entrapta said, one arm crossed against her chest, the other hand touching one finger to her lips. Above her head, her hair mimicked the motion. “And once we get her out, I can set up some experiments to…”

The growl from under the bench kicked up a notch in volume and pitch. Kitten or not, Catra listened to every word they said and was not happy. Wisely, Perfuma backed away.

Glimmer heard the growl, too. She glanced at the workbench and then at Adora, her face tight. “Absolutely not. Where’s Melog?”

“Oh, Melog went to look for our Catra,” Scorpia said. “We… ah… we worried something might go wrong.” She had the grace to look sheepish. “So Melog said that they’d stay here and find her if she got lost. They disappeared as soon as Little Catra appeared. I guess they'll be back once they find her. And then, hopefully, we can reverse the swap.”

“That means I need to rebuild this,” Entrapta gestured at the scattered machinery, “to get her back. I need my workbench, so we should get her out of there as soon as we can.”

Glimmer stood up, briefly pinching the bridge of her nose. Adora thought her eyebrow might be twitching. “Oookay,” she huffed, sounding as though she was getting ready for a pre-battle briefing. She raised her head and squared her shoulders. “We should probably leave,” she told the others softly. “If what we’re dealing with is a five-year-old-Catra, trying to grab her is a terrible idea. Someone could lose an eye.

Adora wondered how Glimmer knew that, but she was grateful for the support.

"It's lunchtime. We'll go get something to eat," Perfuma said brightly. "I bet she's really hungry. We'll bring something down for you two, okay?"

Scorpia nodded vigorously. "I think we got a shipment of food from Salineas. Some tuna might get her to come out."

Numbly, Adora nodded. Glimmer grabbed the others and blinked out. Now that the lab was quiet, Adora clearly heard the continuous growls from the space under the workbench.

Over the past few months, the Fright Zone had been undergoing a transformation. Entrapta's lab was brightly lit, with newly installed skylights letting the daylight in as well as the electric lights. The metal walls had been scrubbed and painted light grey. The whole place looked so different from when it had been the Fright Zone that Catra had to be terrified.

Adora thought for a minute, then got up and turned off all the lights so it was only the filtered natural light that fell into the room and sat down on the floor beside the workbench.

"Did Shadow Weaver send you to get me?" the little girl asked hopefully.

"No… " Well, this was going to be a problem for future Catra. Would talking to the kid change anything? Would Catra even know, or would her memories change because what she remembered happened differently, or would she have two competing sets of memories?

Why the fuck did the portal drop her *here*? "I snuck down. I-I heard that Shadow Weaver locked a kid up down here. I thought I should come down and check to see that you're okay.

“But Shadow Weaver… she said I needed to learn… “ the little girl sniffed, then continued, “not to be scared of the dark.”

Catra was nearly sick on the spot. She remembered this. Why Shadow Weaver had decided that particular night, Adora’s fear of the dark was no longer acceptable, Catra could not recall, but she certainly remembered the aftermath: Adora coming back to the bunkroom after being missing for days, her back ramrod straight and her face serious, and all of the spark snuffed out of her grey eyes.

Glimmer popped in with two plates. One had peanut butter and jelly, and the other had tuna salad- which Catra loved. The Queen bent to whisper in Adora’s ear, “If that doesn’t work, we’ll get Aunt Casta to send over chicken soup.”

Adora smiled lopsidedly. Castaspella’s chicken soup was Catra’s favorite food.

Glimmer patted Adora’s shoulder and said, “I’ll be here the rest of the day. I told everyone at the castle an emergency came up with Scorpia. Bow just got here. Entrapta is working on her calculations. Let us know if you need anything.”

Adora put her hand over Glimmer’s. “Thank you.”

“Yes, of course.” Glimmer squeezed Adora’s shoulder. “She’s my friend too.”

The queen popped out, leaving Adora sitting on the floor with two plates. The blonde woman put the tuna sandwich on the floor about two feet from the workbench and scooted away from it. Then, she applied herself to her own sandwich.

A soft snuffling, more an interruption in the growling than a sound in its own right, announced when Catra got a whiff of the fish.

“Hey there,” Adora said gently. “Do you want something to eat?”

A squeak, a hiss and some shuffling was the response.

Adora pushed the plate closer to the bench. She could see Catra’s hands, her claws digging into the concrete floor. If Adora moved quickly, she could probably grab her by the scruff. And that was probably exactly what Catra was expecting, given how her ears were pinned back and her claws were out.

Adora scooted away, giving the little girl plenty of space. “It’s okay,” she said. “That’s for you.”

Cautiously, Catra inched out, her ears twitching as she looked around to make sure no one else was nearby. Her hand shot out and grabbed the sandwich, retreating quickly to the safety of the darkness.

Another squeak, but this one of delight told Adora that the little girl approved.

“Feel better?” Adora asked softly when she finished her own sandwich.

“Yes?” came the uncertain answer, and Catra came forward again to glare at Adora. “Where am I?”

Adora had no idea what to tell the girl. “Ah… Would you believe this is a dream?” Maybe at five, that would work.

“No,” the child said flatly, her face close enough to the light that Adora could just make out her narrowed eyes and the contemptuous curl of her lip. “I’m not stupid.”

“No, of course not,” Adora agreed quickly. “It’s just… “She was shit at making things up on the fly like this. “Complicated.”

The girl stuck her head all the way out. She sniffed like she was tasting the air. Adora wondered what she could smell. “I-is this a secret lab or something?”

“Yes. Yes, exactly.” Adora breathed a huge sigh of relief, grasping at the lifeline. Trust even Baby Catra to catch on that they were in a lab. The assumption that it was secret would make a lot of sense to the youngster and give Adora something to work with. “I guess you fell into the secret entrance or something.”

“Am I in trouble?” The voice was small and vulnerable.

That was a difficult question to answer. “I hope not,” replied Adora honestly, her heart twisting. “I’m not mad at you, but it would be a good idea if we got you back where you belong before Shadow Weaver finds out or all of us are in trouble.”Adora paused and lowered her voice. “No one wants to get in trouble with Shadow Weaver.

“Yeah, okay,” the child whispered, nodding. The way she just accepted it underlined how much fear of Shadow Weaver permeated the Horde.

“So, uh, listen. We sort of need that workbench to fix the door you came through and get you back. Do you think you could come out?”

Catra squinted up at her for a long minute and then nodded again.

This was just cruel, even for Shadow Weaver. Solitary was bad enough, but now that Catra understood the limitations of Adora’s vision, she realized that to the little girl, it was total darkness.

“Listen… “ Catra struggled to find the words to express the depths of the cold revulsion in her gut. She tried to think what Melog would say. “This is… this isn’t right.”

“Huh?” Adora blinked, looking alarmed. “What… what am I doing wrong?” she asked timidly.

“No, silly.” Naturally, Adora would assume that whatever was wrong was her fault. “ I don’t mean you. I mean… it isn’t right for Shadow Weaver to do this.” It would be great if Melog could make an entrance right about now because Catra was useless at this.

“Why?”

Catra sighed. “Because… Well, just because... You didn’t do anything to deserve this.” Catra leaned forward and took the little girl’s cold hand. “I don’t know how long I can stay, but if you promise not to tell on me, I can keep you company.”

“What if somebody comes?” The fear in the child’s voice was palpable. “I don’t want to get you in trouble.

“No problem. I’ll hear if anyone comes down here way before they see us.” When the child squeezed her hand back, Catra stood and said, “but, come on. I bet we can find a flashlight.”

Tentatively, Baby Catra crawled into the light, and Adora nearly squealed. She had forgotten just how adorable Catra had been at that age. It was a good thing Bow wasn’t here to see this. Even at five, Catra had been sensitive about her dignity. But the downy fluff and the ears she had not yet grown into made Adora’s heart seize up with the desire to scoop her into her arms.

“Hi, there,” Adora said instead, marveling that Catra had ever been this small.

“Um. Hi?” the kitten said softly; she shivered and wrapped her arms around herself.

Something about this situation seemed so familiar to Adora. It reminded her of a story Catra once told her: getting lost and spending an afternoon with a strange force captain in their secret lab. Adora had never really believed her. Did this happen? Was this real?

“Are you cold?” Adora asked.

Somberly, the little girl nodded.

“Put this around you.” Suiting word to deed, Adora doffed her jacket and firmly wrapped Baby Catra in it.“Better?”

The tiny girl purred, a little smile on her lips as she nuzzled into the fabric.

“Let me let my friend know that she can have her workbench back,” Adora said.

“Did I break something?” the fearful tone interrupting the purring made Adora hasten to reassure her.

“No. Not at all. Entrap…” It occurred to Adora suddenly that this could change the present if she told Catra too much. How much would she remember of this as they grew up? Would it matter? “My friend was testing the secret door, and now we’re stuck here until she fixes it.”

“So, where did they go?” Catra asked, looking around. “Don’t you have a normal door?”

“They… “ Adora was a shitty, shitty liar, even when she was lying to a child. How would she keep Catra distracted and safe while giving Entrapta the room she needed to work?

“We went to find the rest of my tools!” Entrapta exclaimed, darting in from the other room. Glimmer must have teleported

into there to avoid alarming the girl. “Thank you for letting me have my workbench back, tiny purrito Catra!”

Catra hissed at Entrapta.

“Oh, wow!” Scorpia seemed to be just barely suppressing the impulse to swoop down and hug the kitten.

Perfuma cooed and burst out, “She is so…”

“How about we find you something to do while Entrapta works on the door?” Adora said loudly, cutting Perfuma off with a glare.

“Like what?” Catra asked.

Adora looked around, feeling lost. More food, maybe? Something to read? Maybe she could get her interested in something on a tracker pad?

“Do you like drawing?” Bow asked before Adora could panic. He and Glimmer came in behind the big woman with crayons and paper.

Catra’s face lit up, and she nodded eagerly.

“Well, come on.” Bow held out his hand. “There’s a table over there we can use.”

The kitten stood up and took his hand, keeping Adora’s jacket around her shoulders. Bow led her over to the other side of the lab.

Adora got up to follow, but Glimmer touched her arm. “Can we talk?”

Numbly, Adora nodded, following Glimmer to where Entrapta was collecting the charred bits of machinery.

It took about half an hour to find a small flashlight in one of the boxes in the warehouse. Catra wondered what time of night it was since there were no windows. She guessed it was late, though, because once they found a flashlight and went to sit near the little cell, Adora began to yawn.

"You sleepy?" Catra asked.

"N-no." Even Baby Adora was a shitty liar.

"Come here, silly," She said, putting her hand around the girl's shoulder. "Lie down. I'll stay with you as long as I can." Catra guided the little girl to lie down with her head in her lap.

This was strange but weirdly sweet, and Catra found herself purring and running her hand through Baby Adora's hair. Idly, she wondered if this would be what it would be like if she and Adora had a child together.

That was a strange thought, and one Catra had never had before. After what happened with Prime, she was not sure she would ever want to carry a child, and she was not sure if Adora could or if becoming She Ra would be a problem, but there were plenty of war orphans.

Could Catra even be a mom? It was not as though she had any good models.

They cuddled up together; it was a little cold. Adora slept while Catra napped with one eye open.

The little girl stirred, her brow was all scrunched up but her eyes were closed. "It's okay." Catra rubbed her shoulder, calming the child.

She was so small. Catra wanted to scoop her up and run away with her. Protect her. But if this was real, then anything that happens might affect the future.

It hurt so much.

What's going on, Glimmer?" Adora asked, concerned. Glimmer was almost vibrating with tension, and she clenched her jaw as though to keep from crying.

"I got Scorpia to tell me why the fuck Entrapta was fooling around with portals." The shorter woman sniffed and seemed to lose her voice, unable to speak. She took a deep breath, cleared her throat, and tried again. "Melog… They found my mom."

"I don't understand."

Glimmer took another deep gasp of air. "My mom. She's alive. Melog knows how to find her."

"Is that where Catra was supposed to go?" Adora's hands jumped up to cover her mouth and nose. A million feelings roiled in her gut- she could not begin to sort them out. She saw Angella's last despairing smile in her mind and knew it was too good to be true, and clearly, it had gone horribly wrong. Catra-- grown Catra-- *her* Catra would never come home, lost the way Angella was.

Adora did not say any of that. She would not take this hope away from Glimmer.

"No." Glimmer shifted from foot to foot as she looked at the soot-smeared machinery Entrapta was rapidly reassembling. "It was just supposed to be a test run. Entrapta is pretty sure she had the power too high. Melog can make a portal, but nothing physical can get through except them, apparently. Scorpia and Entrapta weren't too clear on the details. But, Adora!" The tears fell, spilling down her cheeks over a dazzling smile. "I talked to my dad! He didn't want to tell me until he was sure, but even he didn't know

they were testing it today. They didn't want to raise any false hopes."

Out of all the warring feelings Adora was trying to process, fear and anger floated to the top. "Why didn't she tell me?" wailed Adora more loudly than she intended.

"I don't know. Maybe Catra was afraid you'd tell me?" Glimmer quickly dismissed the question, gripping Adora's biceps and almost dancing in place. *"My mom is alive. "*

Catra inspected the back of her eyelids- no, really, she did. She closed her eyes, imagining the total darkness that Adora would see, and then opened them. To her eyes, the room was dim but not pitch black. Not quite bright enough to read a report but undoubtedly bright enough that she could navigate without tripping.

Now the magicat was doubly relieved that they had never informed anyone about the differences in her eyesight. Shadow Weaver would have put her down here with a bag over her head. How long would Catra be able to cope with that?

Catra always got grounded for longer than Adora did, but being alone and isolated did not seem to bother the magicat as much as it bothered the others. In fact, sometimes it almost felt… she could not say it felt good, but, as punishments went, it was easy to endure. In the quiet isolation, Catra planned campaigns, made up stories, and came up with a million things that she shared with Adora when she got out. And even in the tiny room, there were always mice and bugs to stalk and catch. If Shadow Weaver decided not to feed her, Catra could always use them to supplement her rations.

Adora, on the other hand, always came back looking bad- much worse than Catra ever felt. Come to think of it, after those little disappearances, Catra would not only have to fill Adora in on the lessons she missed in class but also frequently have to relearn some of the skills from prior lessons.

The ugly suspicion that had been growing in Catra's mind for months began to take a definite shape. Shadow Weaver's creepy possessive way of touching Adora.The way the blonde girl would just seem to forget things. Her astonishment at the discovery that Shadow Weaver and Hordak were lying.

Adora was never stupid. It just seemed that she could not hold things in her head. Funny how once she got away from Shadow Weaver, that seemed to stop being a problem.

Fuck it. There was no way Catra could let that happen.

This warehouse had a skiff she could steal. Catra knew how seldom they changed the fucking codes, and the keys were always in the transport vehicles that had not been checked out. She could grab some water and rations, and they could be out of there in less than half an hour.

All things considered, the Crimson Waste wasn't a terrible place to raise a kid. Much better than the Fright Zone, anyway. She would not even need to take over any gangs- Huntara would no doubt take her on.

On second thought, perhaps she should approach Bright Moon's rulers. The Sword would still be in the Whispering Woods,, and Adora could still be She Ra when she was old enough.

Shadow Weaver would look for them, but Catra could certainly handle that. With what Catra knew about the Horde, King Micah would probably take about a week to kick Hordack's ass, and he would love to get his hands on Shadow Weaver before she did any more damage.

All Catra had to do was take the little girl in her arms and make a run for it.

The real Adora. Future Adora. *Her* Adora would understand. And it would be okay because this Adora would be raised by someone who loved her. Even the cover story was easy and obvious. Lots of people had lost spouses to the war. No one would even question her deserting and defecting with her child in tow. Especially since it was apparently common knowledge that Magicat features tended to be recessive (according to Entrapta).

Shadow Weaver would never get her hands on Adora again. The Queen would never get trapped in a pocket dimension. The King would never end up on Beast Island.

At her elbow, a translucent cat appeared. Melog's form was closer to large housecat sized than normal, probably to avoid scaring the girl if she woke up. "You would not have met me, granddaughter," they said softly. "That would grieve me."

Angella being alive was a lot to process, and Adora knew she had nothing useful or helpful to add. She had already failed Glimmer and Angella once. She left Glimmer chattering excitedly at Scorpia and Entrapta and drifted over to check on Catra and Bow.

Apparently, Catra was done with sitting still, because she fidgeted like she always did at the end of class. Much to Adora's surprise, Bow noticed. "Hey," he said. "Look what I found."

It was one of Entrapta's little bots. Bow set it on the ground.

"What does it do?" Catra asked, crouching down to look at it.

"Watch." Bow clicked the remote, and the thing spun around three times before scuttling off towards the junk on the edge of the

room.

The little magicat's pupils went completely round. She glanced up at Bow as if asking for permission. He nodded and smiled at her.

The bot stopped in the middle of the floor as though hesitant. Catra's ears swiveled forward, and she put her hands, then her elbows down on the ground. She bent her knees, wriggling her butt with the end of her tail twitching. Slowly, she picked up one hand at a time, then one foot as she crept forward, silently stalking the thing, leaving Adora's jacket on the ground behind her.

Bow clicked the remote again, and the bot sped off; Catra pounced, releasing all that coiled energy, just barely missing. Giggling, Catra tore after it as it scrambled up the wall and scampered under various pieces of junk and furniture.

Hearing the commotion, Glimmer, Perfuma, and Scorpia came to watch the spectacle of the kitten hunting for the little bot.

"Oh, my stars!" Glimmer giggled as Catra bounced sideways and then clawed her way up a random cable hanging from the ceiling. "That's just… I cannot even!"

"Bow… "Adora began nervously, not wanting the poor thing to get hurt by a live wire.

He anticipated her question. "It's okay. I had Entrapta turn off the power to this side of the lab."

"You're really good with her." Adora could not help the little spike of jealousy as it never occurred to her that the best way to distract a five-year-old Catra would be simply to play with her.

Bow shrugged with that easy smile Adora always envied. "I've babysat some of my brother's kids. It doesn't take much to distract them if you have a new toy," he said.

More quietly, he added, “Glimmer and I were talking about kids.” He lowered his voice, his eyes flicking towards Glimmer for a second. “But since she’s the Queen, we should probably wait until after we get married.”

“Why don’t you just get Scorpia to make you official?” Adora asked absently as she watched Catra gleefully scale one of the grey I-beams. She resisted the urge to call out and tell her to be careful.

“Royal weddings take a long time to plan,” Bow returned. “And it would be really great if Angella was there.”

“Granddaughter, I must tell the technomancer where you are. We will retrieve you.”

Catra looked down at the child asleep next to her. “I can’t leave her here,” Catra whispered. “I just can’t.”

Melog sighed. “It is hard, but the universe has ways of righting itself. Ways that would cause more suffering. What you remember has happened. It is what has always happened, and it is what always will happen. The technomancer’s work nearly destroyed Etheria before.”

Catra pulled her knees up to her chest. “I know, I know.” She did not like to think about that. “I guess… I guess I should fix it.” She sighed. “Can I at least stay with her until the lights come on?” She knew from her times being grounded that the lights switched on for twelve hours a day. It was not a kindness-- too long in the darkness was known to ruin a soldier’s eyes. Catra did not like to think about why Shadow Weaver knew this.

Melog butted their head against Catra’s. “Yes. Of course. That will be two hours from now.”

Catra nodded and pulled her little timekeeper out of her pocket to set an alarm. And then she settled down again with the little girl.

At last, Catra's energy flagged, and her pounces slowed. Bow nudged Adora and pointed at Catra with his chin. She saw that he was allowing the bot to slow just a hair.

"Gotcha!" shrieked Catra, triumphantly grabbing the thing.

The watching adults clapped, with Scorpia hooting and Glimmer cheering.

Catra's face was wreathed in smiles as she basked in the unadulterated praise. She ran to Bow and held up the little bot. "That was so cool!" she said. "Thank you!"

"Oh, hey, you're welcome!" He reached down and ruffled her hair, and she beamed at him.

"Are you a Force Captain?" the little girl asked breathlessly. "Are you in charge of this secret project?"

Bow grinned and crouched down while Glimmer and Scorpia held back their giggles. "Yep. But I'm just here taking care of the science specialists."

"That is so cool!" Catra was still young enough to have no inhibitions against throwing her arms around Bow's neck.

"I think you're pretty cool too."

Little Catra's giant amber and blue eyes filled with tears. "Really?" she gasped, staring up at him.

Without the slightest hesitation, Bow bent and scooped the child up. “Of course. You remind me a lot of a friend of mine, and she’s the coolest. Now, I’m pretty sure we have some applesauce around here for a snack. Have you ever had that?”

“No.”

“It’s serious contraband, so don’t tell anyone where you got it.” Bow walked away with the little girl in his arms, leaving Adora standing awkwardly alone as Glimmer and Scorpia resumed their excited conversation.

Melog bumped Adora’s hand with their nose. “Entrapta!” Adora spun around, “Melog’s back!”

Catra’s alarm vibrated in her pocket, bringing her fully awake. The lights would come on in fifteen minutes, so she had time to tell her what was happening.

“Hey, Adora?” she shook the girl. “The lights are going to come on in a minute, so you should…” Catra shuddered, “get back in there.”

“Can I keep this?” the little girl asked, holding up the flashlight.

“Yeah. Hide it good, though.”

“Will you come back?”

Catra swallowed. “No. I’m sorry. I can’t. If Shadow Weaver catches me, she’ll send me to Beast Island.”

Soberly, the girl nodded. “Okay. I’ll try to be brave. I promise.”

That did it. Catra gathered the child into her arms, picking her up and taking her into the cell. The only comfort the child had been given was a sleeping bag on the floor. “You are already brave,” Catra whispered. “You are brave and smart and good at so many things. Don’t let anyone tell you different, okay?”

Gently, Catra tucked the girl into her sleeping bag and kissed her on the forehead. Then she stood and shut the door behind her. It was the hardest thing she had ever done.

Once Melog had returned, it did not take long for Entrapta to get the portal generator up and running again. Melog stepped through with tiny Catra on their back. The next moment, Melog stepped out with grown Catra, who threw herself into Adora's waiting arms.

"Are you okay?" Demanded Adora, alarmed at seeing her wife's tear-streaked face.

Catra could not seem to speak for a second as she buried her face in Adora's shoulder, holding on just as tightly as she did on Darla. Finally, she whispered, "I can't talk about it. Can we just go home?"

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